

Panelists



Abhishek Satish, Co-founder
and Director, Vicara



Amit Satpathy, EVP & Head,
Vodafone Idea IoT Business



Anand Bhandari, NB-IoT, Smart
Utilities and Smart Assets, JioThings



Trushit Buch, India Lead,
Codify Inc.

ment IoT solutions for the benefit of humans. However, shutdowns during Covid-19 have made the manufacturing industries think more about IoT. The recovery in the manufacturing sector, as per a Deloitte report, may take longer to reach pre-pandemic levels. Projections based on the Oxford Economic Model anticipate a decline in annual manufacturing GDP growth level by as much as 3.5% for 2021.

Distribution companies, as per the Deloitte report, are investing in IoT at a substation level to better forecast demand. Smart electricity meters are in fact the biggest example of how big the IoT vertical is getting, and these smart meters will likely enable more IoT-related use case development.

Similarly, managing and monitoring large-scale wind and solar farms is also a problem that can easily be addressed with IoT. The government of India has set a target of achieving 175GW of renewable energy capacity. This target includes 100GW of solar energy and 60GW of wind energy by 2022.

In healthcare sector, IoT-enabled devices like wristbands and smart watches with heart monitoring and heart rhythm detection have already proved their worth.

In agriculture sector, India has not done much in terms of empowering it with IoT, despite a majority of India's population depending on agriculture as their primary source of income. The government of India, as per the Deloitte report, is advocating the use of sensors in agriculture value chain. The deployment of IoT sensors to collect and transmit data in agricultural activities will lead to the development of advanced techniques in precision agriculture monitoring.

"Other sectors, such as automotive, metals, and mining, are also deriving significant value from IoT. Therefore, this allows us to predict that IoT is expected to become a key investment area around later 2021, once cash flows improve," reads the report by Deloitte.

It is critical for startups in the IoT ecosystem to realise that unless the solutions they are offering are giving their customers 4x to 5x return on investment, the solutions will not be adopted widely. It is better to realise this in the pre-stages of developing a solution than after burning money. Startups, in most cases, are usually short on finance, and such mistakes only aggravate their problems. The best way to make sure that the solution a startup is offering would deliver that kind of RoI starts with the time a creator spends with the customer. More the time spent, more is the understanding developed between the creator and the customer on what the latter really wants to achieve.

"Startups should not go too niche as well. It is extremely important that you take the first few steps right. People who you partner with are extremely important. It is better to reach clients through an accelerator or an incubator instead of going and pitching the solution to a client directly," advises Abhishek.

"What the startups need to do is, think more on the execution side. They have to be able to say that I might or might not be able to support pan-India operations, but I can definitely support 24x7 in Bengaluru, Delhi, Mumbai, or a region they have the strongest presence in. It is usually the execution that is the more

difficult part," says Amit.

Startups, as per Trushit, should not go too much into innovation. The innovation that they should focus on must be in terms of the after-sale services they offer. They could work on innovation that helps them better their connections with the industry, partners, and their clients. The focus should be on innovation for a vertical, and then how they can apply the same innovation in different verticals.

Amit adds, "Startups should not burn their money on tweaking products just to meet demands of a single client. They should also restrain themselves from becoming R&D centres for large organisations who offer them free-of-cost PoCs. The way to do this right is by collaborating with some large trustworthy and transparent organisations."

"Initially, it takes a long time, but if in the long run you are able to get ten logos which are really referenceable, you can create your kingdom on that," says Trushit.

Additionally, startups should never underestimate the service part, as it can help with a tremendous amount of revenue. The biggest areas where IoT startups can start are remote working, telehealth, and e-commerce. Remote working makes every enterprise a potential customer, and startups should never forget that.

As Amit concludes, "Startups are the arteries of the IoT ecosystem!" **EFY**

This article is based on a panel discussion held during the IoT Startups Show on the Tech World Congress Platform.

Mukul Yudhveer Singh is technology journalist at EFY